From Conflict to Governance (FC2G): Participatory Communication and Public Engagement in Syria after the fall of the Assad Regime

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Abstract

This study examines how communication and public participation is being reshaped in Syria after the fall of the Assad regime. While participation is often promoted as a key component of inclusive governance in post-conflict settings, there remains limited empirical understanding of how it is practiced and experienced in transitional contexts such as Syria. This research addresses this gap by exploring the interaction between citizens, local governance actors, and communication processes across different governance environments.

Adopting a qualitative and interpretivist approach, the study is based on a multiple case study design focusing on three contexts: Damascus and Rural Damascus, Northwest Syria, and Northeast Syria. Data was collected through semi-structured interviews with participants involved in local governance, civil society, and humanitarian work, complemented by document and discourse analysis. The analysis is guided by theoretical perspectives on participatory democracy, power and participation, and Communication for Development (ComDev).

The findings reveal that participation in Syria is not structured through formal institutional mechanisms alone, but emerges through hybrid and mediated processes involving local intermediaries, civil society actors, and humanitarian organisations. Participation is often expressed through community consultations, needs assessments, informal networks, and digital communication platforms. However, while access to participation has increased in some contexts, the extent of influence on decision-making remains unbalanced. The study highlights a persistent tension between inclusion and actual power, where participation is frequently consultative rather than transformative.

Communication is identified as a central dimension shaping participation, influencing information flows, legitimacy, and the relationship between citizens and institutions. The results further demonstrate that governance in transitional Syria is characterised by fluidity, negotiation, and the coexistence of formal and informal structures.

Overall, the study contributes to ComDev by providing an empirically grounded analysis of participation as a dynamic, communicative, and power-laden process in post-conflict transition settings.

Abbreviations

- **ComDev** - Communication for Development
- **CFSC** – Communication for Social Change
- **FSA –** Free Syrian Army
- **HTS –** Hay'at Tahrir al-Sham
- **SSG –** Syrian Salvation Government
- **SDF –** Syrian Democratic Forces
- **NGO –** Non-Governmental Organization
- **INGO –** International Non-Governmental Organization
- **UN –** United Nations
- **HRW –** Human Rights Watch
- **SYDF –** Syrian Development Fund
- **EUAA** - European Union Agency for Asylum

Chapter 1. Introduction

1.1 Background

The authoritarian system established under Hafez al-Assad and later maintained by Bashar al-Assad can be understood as a coercive political structure operating through both repression and symbolic control. Following the Corrective Movement on 16 November 1970, the Syrian regime consolidated authority through the Ba'ath Party and an extensive security apparatus, producing what Hinnebusch (2001) describes as a highly institutionalized "security state." During this period, the Baʿth state was transformed into a centralized and increasingly personalized authoritarian system in which "Asad made the presidency the undisputed command post of the Ba'th state and, through it, concentrated personalised authority in his hands" (Hinnebusch, 2001, p. 63). While coercion, including detention, torture, and surveillance, remained central to regime durability, authoritarian control also extended deeply into social and political life. Under Hafez al-Assad (1970–2000), independent political activity and civil society were heavily restricted and reorganized under state authority. Wedeen (1999) describes this system as one of performative compliance, where citizens publicly enacted loyalty regardless of genuine belief. These practices normalized submission and reinforced hierarchical power relations in everyday life. This dynamic also reflects Foucault's (1977) concept of disciplinary power, in which surveillance and self-regulation shape individual behavior beyond direct repression.

In Syria, the widespread presence of intelligence agencies and the constant possibility of monitoring encouraged self-censorship and limited public engagement, as many people avoided political expression out of fear of consequences. At the same time, coercion remained a defining feature of the regime. Incidents such as the Hama Massacre in 1982 demonstrated how violent repression was used to silence dissent and enforce political boundaries (Human Rights Watch, 1996).

After the death of Hafez al-Assad, Bashar al-Assad assumed power in 2000, initially creating limited expectations for political reform. During the period known as the "Damascus Spring", intellectuals, activists, and civil society actors called for greater political freedoms through public forums and debate, but the movement was soon

suppressed through arrests and renewed restrictions on political expression (Amnesty International, 2004). Although Bashar al-Assad adopted a discourse of modernization and reform, authoritarian structures remained largely intact. As Heydemann (2007) argues, such reforms often preserve existing authoritarian structures rather than produce genuine political liberalization, ultimately serving to reinforce regime power. At the same time, expanding digital technologies introduced new dimensions of surveillance and control. Online spaces became increasingly monitored, extending authoritarian practices into emerging communicative environments and reinforcing self-censorship among users. Reports by Human Rights Watch (2010) document how bloggers, journalists, and activists faced arrest and harassment, illustrating how authoritarian control adapted to new forms of communication while maintaining broader systems of coercion and disciplinary power.

The outbreak of the Syrian revolution during the Arab Spring in 2011 marked a major turning point in Syria's modern history. The uprising began in Daraa after schoolchildren were arrested and tortured for writing anti-regime slogans, triggering widespread protests against the Assad regime. What started as localized demonstrations quickly spread across the country, as Syrians mobilized to demand freedom, dignity, social justice, and political reform. In its early stages, the uprising was largely peaceful and expressed through demonstrations, sit-ins, chants, and grassroots civic initiatives. For many Syrians, this period represented an unprecedented experience of collective participation after decades of political exclusion. However, the regime responded with escalating violence, including arrests, live ammunition, and large-scale military operations. As repression intensified, military defections led to the formation of the Free Syrian Army (FSA), contributing to the gradual transformation of the uprising into an armed conflict.

Despite the violence, civic participation did not disappear but instead adapted into new forms. Syrians continued to engage through protests, grassroots initiatives, and civic organizing both inside Syria and in the diaspora. In areas outside regime control, particularly in Idlib and northern Syria, local councils and civil initiatives emerged to manage daily life and provide services. These efforts reflected attempts to create alternative forms of governance and local participation under conditions of instability. This reflects Servaes' understanding of community empowerment as collective action rooted in the participation of individuals and organizations within their social context,

enabling communities to generate forms of self-organization and social change from below (Servaes, 2021, p. 294). The collapse of state institutions created governance vacuums that grassroots actors sought to address through local councils, civil society groups, and alternative media platforms, including initiatives such as the revolutionary council in Manbij (Munif, 2020, p. 146). Although these initiatives differed in structure and function, they demonstrated communities' capacity to self-organize and respond to local needs. At the same time, the conflict became increasingly complex due to the involvement of regional and international actors, as well as the rise of multiple armed groups, including ISIS and various Islamist and opposition factions. The Syrian regime also received direct support from Russia, Iran, and allied militias such as Hezbollah. These developments intensified the fragmentation of the conflict landscape and produced a highly contested governance environment. The use of sieges, starvation, and chemical weapons further deepened the humanitarian crisis and constrained civic space. Nevertheless, civic engagement persisted, often in localized and informal forms, highlighting both the resilience of Syrian communities and the limitations imposed by war and repression.

In Idlib, Hay'at Tahrir al-Sham (HTS) gradually consolidated control through military dominance and shifting alliances (Grant, 2023, p. 51–52). By 2017–2019, HTS had become the de facto authority in the region. As part of this process, HTS supported the establishment of the Syrian Salvation Government (SSG), a civilian administrative structure responsible for sectors such as education, healthcare, and local administration (Grant, 2023, p. 63). Although formally presented as separate, the SSG operates closely alongside HTS governance structures. Local councils and civil society actors continue to function within this environment, though often under significant political and security constraints. Despite these pressures, civic engagement in Idlib has continued to adapt through local organizing, service provision, and community-based responses to conflict, displacement, and scarcity. These dynamics illustrate how collective agency and local forms of participation have persisted despite ongoing fracturing and instability.

1.2 Syria in Transition

8 December 2024 marked a significant milestone in Syria, representing for many Syrians a historic moment in their long struggle against authoritarian rule. After decades under the Assad family and nearly fifty-five years of dictatorship, this moment came to

embody hopes of breaking with a system long defined by repression, fear, and coercive control. For many, it signaled the possibility of political change that had previously seemed unattainable. While the path toward transformation remains uncertain, the moment carried strong symbolic weight, reflecting both societal resilience and a long-standing aspiration for freedom. The transfer of power signaled a domestic transition and a reconfiguration of Syria's regional and international position. This new phase introduced significant challenges linked to state reconstruction after decades of authoritarian governance and prolonged conflict (Simon Gureshidze 2025). Central to this period is the question of legitimacy, as the transitional leadership seeks to consolidate authority across a socially and politically divided society while rebuilding state institutions. Emerging from an armed background, the leadership has attempted to reposition itself within a governance framework focused on administration and international engagement (Simon Gureshidze 2025).

The legacy of war, competing power centres, and long-term divisions continues to shape governance and participation. In this sense, "liberation" does not represent an endpoint but the beginning of an ongoing process in which authority and statehood are continuously renegotiated. At the same time, the fall of the regime did not automatically dismantle the deeper structures of control embedded in Syrian society. While the removal of Assad marked a major political rupture, many institutional and security practices linked to authoritarian rule have persisted or re-emerged in new forms. This illustrates how control was not only institutional but also socially embedded over time. Nevertheless, the transition has opened new civic spaces. Compared to the previous period, many Syrians can now express opinions more openly, engage in public debate, and organise community initiatives with greater visibility than before. This shift reflects an important change in public life, where fear has partially declined and new forms of participation have begun to emerge (Haid Haid, p. 12).

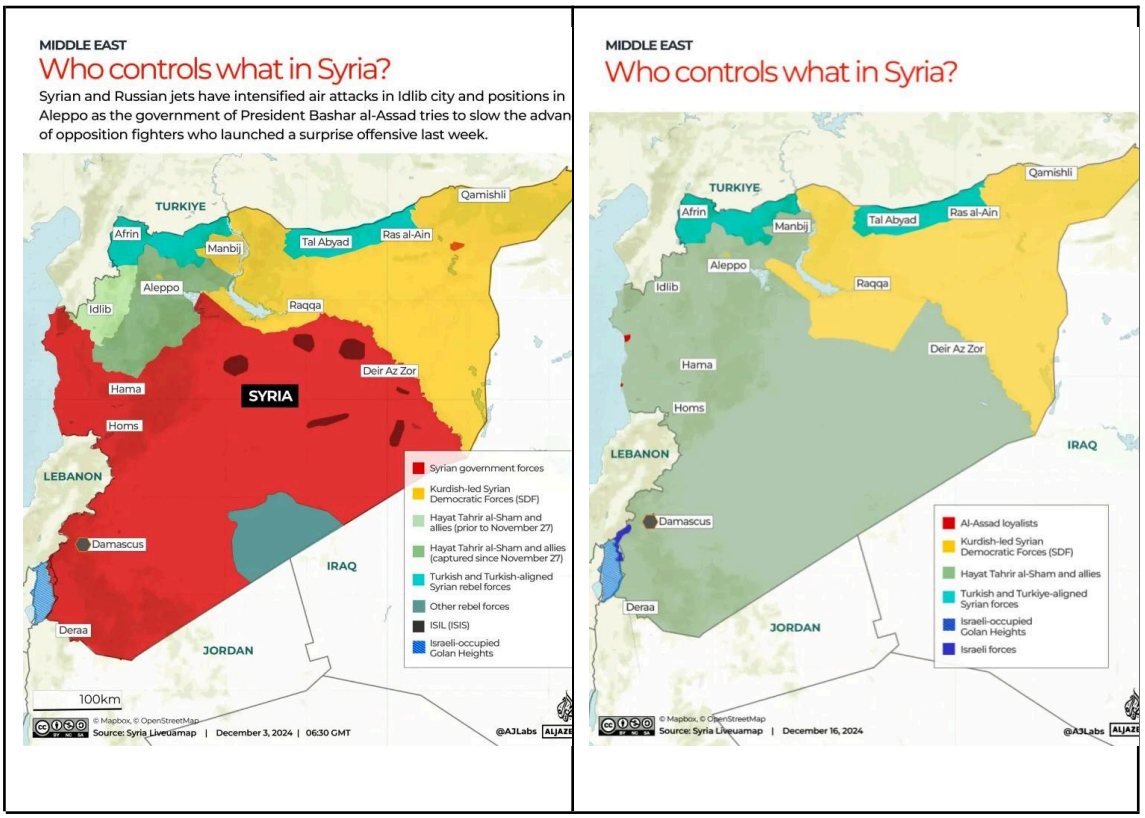


Figure 1 Syria map, 3 december and 16 december 2024 - (**AJLaps** from Syria **Liveuamap**)

An important development within this transitional phase is the evolving relationship between the Syrian transitional government and the Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF) in northeastern Syria. Following periods of military confrontation and territorial shifts in early 2026, both sides moved toward ceasefire and integration agreements aimed at reducing conflict and restoring state authority in formerly autonomous areas. According to the EUAA (2026), these agreements include the gradual integration of Kurdish-led military forces into the Syrian army and the incorporation of civilian institutions into national structures. They also introduce provisions recognising aspects of Kurdish cultural and civil rights, including the official use of the Kurdish language and protections for displaced communities (EUAA 2026, pp. 6–10). However, the process remains fragile and contested. Despite formal agreements, tensions, sporadic clashes, displacement, and allegations of abuses continue to shape the security situation in northeastern Syria throughout 2026. These dynamics reflect the broader difficulty of rebuilding governance and cohesion in a context marked by long-term divisions and competing political projects. Rather than a completed settlement, the integration process illustrates an ongoing negotiation over authority, participation, and state formation in post-conflict Syria.

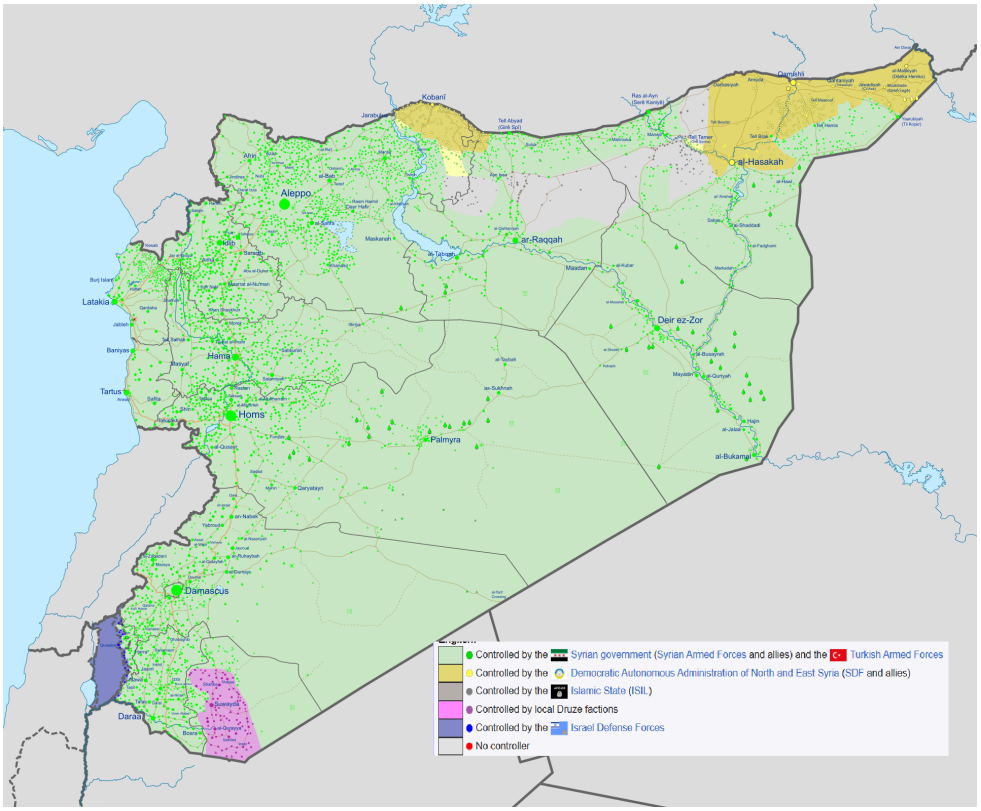


Figure 2 Syria map 2026 feb. https://sv.wikipedia.org/wiki/Fil:Syrian_Civil_War_map.svg (Wikipedia)

1.3 The Problem

Despite the increasing role of local governance structures and civic engagement in Syria's transitional context, there is still limited understanding of how public participation actually operates in practice. Existing discussions are often influenced by earlier state-centered governance models, externally designed policy approaches, or broad post-conflict frameworks that do not fully reflect the realities of different Syrian communities. As a result, participation is frequently presented as a formal governance principle rather than examined as a process shaped by local political, social, and institutional conditions. A key problem is the lack of clarity regarding how citizens can meaningfully engage in decision-making processes and influence local governance. Participation mechanisms are often unclear, inconsistent, or accessible only to limited groups, while communication between citizens and governance actors remains weak. These challenges highlight the limited understanding of how participation is experienced and communicated within Syria's evolving governance context. This study therefore examines participation through formal institutions, everyday interactions and local forms of engagement.

1.4 Research Questions

This study is guided by one main research question and two sub-questions. Together, they aim to explore how public participation is being reshaped in Syria after the fall of the Assad regime, with a specific focus on the interaction between citizens, local governance actors, and communication processes.

Main Research Question:

How have patterns of communication and public participation in Syria changed after the fall of the Assad regime?

Sub-questions:

1. How do citizens interact with local governance actors and community leadership structures in their everyday contexts?
2. How is participation framed, communicated, and facilitated by institutions and civil society actors within local governance settings?

These questions are designed to capture both the practical and communicative dimensions of participation. The first sub-question focuses on lived experiences and direct forms of engagement between citizens and local actors. The second sub-question examines the role of communication practices, institutional narratives, and civil society mediation in shaping how participation is understood and enacted.

Together, these questions allow for a comprehensive analysis of participation as both a social practice and a communicative process within Syria's evolving governance landscape.

1.5 Significance of the Study

This study is significant at academic, practical, and policy-related levels. It contributes to understanding how public participation is experienced, communicated, and negotiated within Syria's transitional governance context, while also offering insights relevant to governance practices, civic engagement, and reconstruction processes.

Academic significance

From an academic perspective, the study contributes to the field of ComDev by examining participation within a complex post-conflict and post-authoritarian environment. While participatory governance and participatory communication have been widely discussed theoretically, limited empirical research has explored how these processes operate in Syria's current transitional context. The study therefore addresses an important research gap by analyzing participation as a process shaped by institutions, communication practices, power relations, social trust, and local dynamics.

Practical significance

At a practical level, the study provides insights into how citizens, civil society actors, local communities, and governance institutions engage with participatory processes during transition. These findings may support practitioners, development organizations, and community initiatives in designing more inclusive and context-sensitive approaches to participation, communication, and civic engagement. The study also highlights the importance of dialogue and community-based engagement in rebuilding trust and strengthening relationships between citizens and governance institutions.

Policy significance

From a policy perspective, the study emphasizes the importance of flexible and context-sensitive approaches to participation in societies emerging from conflict and authoritarian rule. The findings may assist policymakers, local administrations, civil society organizations, and international actors in developing governance and reconstruction strategies that are more inclusive, participatory, and responsive to local realities. Ultimately, the study contributes to broader discussions on how participation, communication, and governance can support long-term social development and more community-oriented forms of transition and reconstruction in Syria.

1.6 Outline of Empirical Data and Key Findings

The findings show that participation in Syria's transitional context varies across regions and is shaped by different local governance arrangements rather than operating through a unified national system. While opportunities for public engagement, civic expression,

and local initiatives have expanded compared to previous periods, participation remains largely consultative, with limited influence over strategic decision-making processes. Across all regions, citizens often participate through informal networks, NGOs, digital platforms, local councils, and intermediary actors rather than through fully institutionalized participatory mechanisms. Participation is also increasingly shaped through dialogue and interaction between communities and institutions, particularly through locally driven initiatives, informal communication channels, and community-based consultation processes.

The study also demonstrates that participation is strongly influenced by communication practices, trust relations, and the enduring social legacy of authoritarian governance. Although digital platforms and community initiatives have created new spaces for interaction and public expression, participants consistently described a continuing gap between citizens and institutions, where inclusion often remains symbolic or procedural rather than transformative. Taken together, the findings suggest that participation in transitional Syria is shaped through continuous interaction between emerging local agencies, institutional restructuring, and persistent power hierarchies within evolving governance environments.

Chapter 2. Literature Review

2.1 Authoritarianism and Power in Syria

The Syrian political system can be understood through scholarship that examines coercion, institutions, surveillance, and symbolic domination. The works of Raymond Hinnebusch, Lisa Wedeen, Michel Foucault, and Steven Heydemann offer important perspectives for analysing the durability of the Assad state and the broader dynamics of authority in Syria.

Raymond Hinnebusch (2001) explains how Hafez al-Assad consolidated authority through the presidency, the Baʿath Party, and the security apparatus, transforming Syria into a highly centralized state. He argues that Assad made the presidency the central command position of the Baʿth state, concentrating political authority around personal rule. According to Hinnebusch, stability depended on repression, as well as patronage

networks, institutional dominance, and restrictions on civil society and political participation. His work highlights the structural foundations that enabled the state to maintain long-term dominance.

Lisa Wedeen (1999) examines the symbolic dimension of domination. In *Ambiguities of Domination*, she introduces the concept of "performative compliance," arguing that citizens participated in rituals of loyalty regardless of their true beliefs. These performances normalized submission and reinforced awareness of authority through slogans, symbols, and public displays of loyalty. Rather than relying solely on coercion, Wedeen shows how domination was reproduced through everyday practices and cultural performances that shaped social behavior.

Michel Foucault's theory of disciplinary power also helps explain mechanisms of control in Syria. In *Discipline and Punish* (1977), Foucault argues that modern societies operate through surveillance and self-regulation, where individuals internalize the feeling of being constantly watched. In Syria, the widespread presence of intelligence agencies fostered fear and self-censorship, shaping behavior even without direct repression. His perspective demonstrates how surveillance becomes embedded in everyday social relations, although his framework pays less attention to the direct violence that also characterized Syrian politics.

Steven Heydemann's concept of "upgrading authoritarianism" (2007) further explains how governments adapt in order to survive. He argues that several Arab states adopted the language of modernization and reform without introducing genuine political liberalization.

Bashar al-Assad promoted an image of economic reform and technological modernization while preserving centralized authority and limiting political freedoms. Heydemann's analysis shows how reform rhetoric was used strategically to strengthen legitimacy without fundamentally changing the political system.

Although these scholars focus on different dimensions of rule in Syria, their arguments complement one another. Hinnebusch emphasizes institutional structures, while Wedeen highlights symbolic and performative forms of domination. Foucault contributes a broader understanding of surveillance and disciplinary practices, whereas Heydemann explains how governments adapt and modernize to preserve authority. Combined, their

work demonstrates that Syrian rule operated through interconnected mechanisms, including coercion, symbolic domination, surveillance, institutional centralization, and controlled modernization. These perspectives are essential for understanding the durability of the Assad state and the broader dynamics of participation, resistance, and social control in Syrian society.

2.2 Participation, Communication, and Governance

Participation, communication, and governance have been widely discussed in development studies and democratic theory, particularly in relation to power, inclusion, and citizen agency. Key scholars such as Sherry R. Arnstein, John Gaventa, Thomas Tufte, Paolo Mefalopulos, and Jan Servaes offer important perspectives for understanding how participation functions within governance structures and communicative processes.

Sherry R. Arnstein's "Ladder of Citizen Participation" (1969) is one of the most influential frameworks in this field. She understands participation as a question of power distribution and argues that many forms of participation are not truly democratic. Her ladder ranges from non-participation and tokenism to citizen power, including partnership, delegated power, and citizen control. Arnstein's model shows that participation without real influence risks becoming symbolic. Similarly, John Gaventa (2009) emphasizes that participation depends on creating inclusive spaces where marginalized groups can express voice and influence decisions. Both scholars highlight that meaningful participation requires shifts in power relations rather than consultation alone.

While Arnstein focuses primarily on participation within governance and decision-making structures, Thomas Tufte approaches participation from a ComDev perspective. In *Communication and Social Change* (2017), Tufte broadens this discussion by focusing on communicative processes. He argues that participation is not limited to formal decision-making but also involves dialogue, meaning-making, and collective action. He distinguishes between one-way communication and dialogic communication, where exchange and interaction enable engagement and social change. This shifts attention from structures of participation to the processes through which participation is enacted.

Although Arnstein and Tufte both emphasize participation and empowerment, their approaches differ in important ways. Arnstein's model is primarily concerned with the distribution of decision-making power between citizens and authorities. Her framework evaluates participation according to the extent to which citizens can influence governance outcomes. Tufte, in contrast, focuses more on communication processes and the importance of dialogue, inclusion, and citizen expression. While Arnstein conceptualizes participation through hierarchical levels of power, Tufte understands participation as a communicative and relational process shaped through interaction and collective meaning-making. Despite these differences, both scholars share a critical perspective toward symbolic or superficial participation and argue that genuine participation requires active citizen agency and opportunities for influence.

Paolo Mefalopulos (2008) further develops participatory communication by outlining levels ranging from passive participation and consultation to collaboration and empowerment. His framework aligns with Arnstein's distinction between symbolic and meaningful participation. Alongside Tufte, he emphasizes that participatory communication can support local ownership, advocacy, and community engagement. Jan Servaes (2021) also highlights the central role of dialogue in development and social change. He argues that communication should be a participatory process that enables reflection, collective action, and empowerment, rather than a top-down transfer of information. This becomes especially relevant in contexts where participation emerges through civil society, grassroots initiatives, and local networks.

The study does not introduce a new theory of participation; rather, it demonstrates how existing frameworks from participatory communication and participatory governance help contextualize Arnstein's model within the Syrian transitional setting. Scholars such as Tufte, Servaes, and Mefalopulos conceptualize participation as a communicative, relational, and culturally embedded process, which aligns closely with the informal, negotiated, and digitally mediated practices observed in this study. Similarly, Gaventa's analysis of power and participatory spaces provides a more flexible lens for understanding how Syrians navigate invited, claimed, and closed spaces of engagement. Together, these perspectives complement Arnstein by offering a more context-sensitive understanding of participation in transitional and authoritarian environments.

Drawing on these scholars, this study provides an analytical framework for understanding participation, communication, and governance. Arnstein and Gaventa foreground how participation is shaped by power relations and access to decision-making within governance structures, while Tufte, Mefalopulos, and Servaes shift attention to communicative interaction, dialogue, and participatory communication as drivers of social change. When considered together, these approaches show that participation is more than a single or stable condition, but a contested process shaped by both institutional structures and communicative dynamics. This analytical framework is used to analyze how participation is negotiated, enabled, or constrained within Syria's transitional governance context.

2.3 Research Gap

Despite the growing literature on participation, governance, civil society, and post-conflict reconstruction, there remains limited understanding of how public participation is evolving within Syria's current transitional context. Existing research often focuses on pre-conflict governance structures, humanitarian responses during the war, or broader theoretical discussions of participation, while giving less attention to how participation is experienced and practiced during ongoing political transition. In particular, there is limited empirical research on everyday participation at the local level, including how citizens interact with governance actors, communicate community needs, and engage outside formal institutional frameworks.

Another important gap concerns the communicative dimension of participation. Although ComDev literature emphasizes dialogue, information exchange, and meaning-making, these aspects remain underexplored in studies of Syria. There is still limited understanding of how formal and informal communication channels shape participation, legitimacy, and relations between citizens and governance actors. At the same time, much of the literature approaches participation as a normative or standardized concept, overlooking the complexity of transitional contexts where governance structures, authority, and power relations remain unstable and contested. Existing studies also tend to generalize Syria as a single governance context despite important regional differences in institutional structures and local political dynamics.

Finally, these gaps highlight the need for more grounded and context-sensitive research on participation within Syria's evolving governance landscape. This study therefore seeks to contribute to a deeper empirical understanding of participation by examining how it is practiced, communicated, and negotiated in everyday life, while bridging perspectives from governance studies and Communication for Development.

Chapter 3. Theoretical Framework

This chapter presents the theoretical framework used to analyze public participation in Syria's transitional governance context. The framework combines three interrelated perspectives: power and participation, participatory communication, and participatory governance. Together, these perspectives allow participation to be understood not only as a political process linked to governance and decision-making, but also as a communicative process shaped by dialogue, inclusion, and power relations.

3.1 Power and Participation

The relationship between power and participation is central to understanding how participatory processes function in practice. Sherry R. Arnstein provides a particularly influential framework for analyzing the different degrees of citizen involvement in decision-making processes through her model known as the "Ladder of Citizen Participation." Developed in 1969, Arnstein argues that "participation of the governed in their government is, in theory, the cornerstone of democracy,"(Arnstein, 1969, p.216) emphasizing that citizen involvement is widely regarded as a fundamental democratic principle. However, her framework conceptualizes participation as a question of power distribution, arguing that participation without genuine influence over decisions risks becoming symbolic rather than meaningful. Similarly, John Gaventa emphasizes that meaningful participation requires both active citizen engagement and institutional willingness to create inclusive forms of governance. He argues that participation enables marginalized groups to exercise voice through mechanisms of inclusion, consultation, and mobilization designed to influence institutions and policies (Gaventa, 2009).

Arnstein's model presents participation as an eight-rung ladder that reflects increasing levels of citizen power. The lower rungs, manipulation and therapy, represent forms of

non-participation where authorities primarily seek to educate or persuade citizens rather than involve them in decision-making. The middle rungs, informing, consultation, and placation, represent forms of tokenism in which citizens may be heard but lack the power to ensure their views influence outcomes. At the highest levels, partnership, delegated power, and citizen control, citizens gain increasing degrees of decision-making authority and influence over policies and governance processes (Arnstein, 1969, pp 218-220)

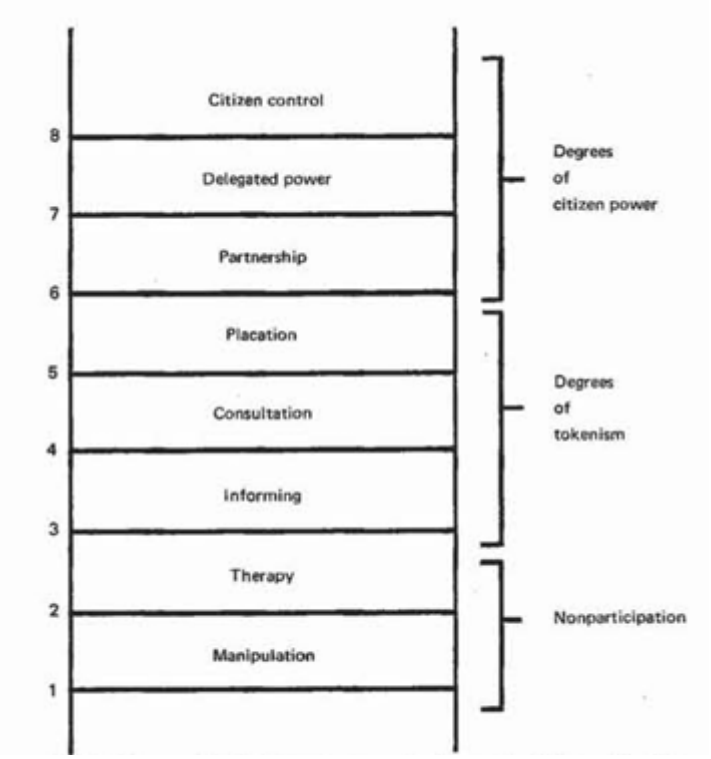


Figure 3 Sherry Arnstein's ladder of participation, Arnstein (1969, p 217)

This framework is particularly relevant in contexts of governance transition, where participatory mechanisms may formally exist but where actual influence over decisions remains unevenly distributed. Arnstein's model highlights that participation should not only be assessed by the presence of consultation mechanisms, but also by examining the extent to which citizens can genuinely shape outcomes and hold decision-makers accountable.

In the Syrian context, participation is influenced by complex political, social, and institutional dynamics. Citizens may engage in local governance processes through consultations, civil society initiatives, or community meetings; however, the degree of

influence they hold within these spaces may vary significantly. Arnstein's framework helps to analyze whether these participatory spaces function primarily as symbolic forms of inclusion or whether they provide meaningful opportunities for citizens to influence governance and decision-making during the transitional period. Furthermore, the framework draws attention to existing power asymmetries between citizens, local authorities, and intermediary actors such as civil society organizations. In transitional governance settings, where institutions may be fragmented and trust in public authority remains fragile, understanding the distribution of decision-making power becomes essential for evaluating the depth and effectiveness of public participation.

3.2 Participatory communication

The second component of the theoretical framework focuses on participatory communication as a central process in the construction of participation and social change. From a ComDev perspective, participation is not only concerned with decision-making structures, but also with the communicative processes through which people express needs, negotiate meanings, and influence collective realities. Thomas Tufte argues that participatory communication is commonly associated with two main areas of action: communication within development projects, which is closely linked to development cooperation and institutional initiatives, and community-based participatory communication, which is connected to more informal citizen-led initiatives and grassroots action. While institutional participatory communication is often associated with system-driven communication practices, community-based participatory communication is more strongly linked to bottom-up and citizen-driven forms of engagement focused on social and structural change. (2017, p 83-84)

This latter form of participatory communication has traditionally been connected to community media, alternative media, citizen media, and social movement communication, all of which emphasize local participation, dialogue, and empowerment. However, participatory communication is not limited to either institutions or grassroots movements alone; rather, it may occur across both formal and informal settings. According to Tufte and Paolo Mefalopulos, participation in development contexts can serve multiple functions, including improving service delivery, supporting advocacy efforts, facilitating local reflection and learning, and involving communities in monitoring and evaluation processes. (2009, p. 5)

Within this perspective, Mefalopulos identifies different levels of participation ranging from passive participation and consultation to collaboration and empowerment participation (Mefalopulos, 2008). These forms represent a continuum of citizen engagement, moving from limited involvement toward more equal forms of partnership and shared decision-making. This understanding closely resonates with Sherry R. Arnstein's distinction between symbolic participation and genuine citizen power.

Participatory communication also highlights the importance of dialogue. Thomas Tufte distinguishes between monologic communication, based on one-way information flows, and dialogic communication, which emphasizes mutual exchange, participation, and collective meaning-making. From this perspective, communication is understood as a process that enables citizens to express agency, negotiate shared understandings, and participate in social change (Tufte 2017, p. 84). The importance of dialogue within participatory communication is further emphasized by Jan Servaes, who argues that: "If there is only one thing that we can all learn from participatory communication experiences and their mixed results, it is that dialogue is the key for development. If civil society is to take a larger role in conceiving and working for development, then dialogue is unavoidable" (Servaes 2021, p. 96). Dialogic communication is particularly important in transitional contexts, where participation, trust, and inclusion are often shaped through community networks, media, and communicative spaces rather than through formal institutions alone.

In the Syrian context, participatory communication provides a useful framework for understanding how citizens engage with governance processes both within and outside formal institutions. Participation may take place through local councils, civil society organizations, community initiatives, or informal communication networks. Access to communication channels, opportunities for dialogue, and the ability to shape narratives all influence how participation is experienced and whose voices are recognized. This framework therefore emphasizes that participation is not only about institutional inclusion, but also about creating communicative spaces that support bottom-up, community-based, and grassroots-oriented forms of empowerment and social change.

Participatory communication therefore provides a process-oriented perspective on participation by examining how communication practices enable or restrict citizen engagement. Rather than viewing communication as a one-way transfer of information,

this framework emphasizes dialogue, community-driven meaning-making, and the role of communication in empowerment. In transitional and post-authoritarian contexts such as Syria, participatory communication helps analyze how citizens express agency through formal and informal communication spaces, including local networks, civil society initiatives, and digital media platforms. It also highlights how opportunities for dialogue may expand or become constrained depending on political, social, and institutional conditions.

3.3 Participatory Governance

Participatory governance offers an institutional framework for understanding how citizens engage with governance processes and how participation becomes embedded in decision-making. In contrast to top-down governance models, it emphasizes the involvement of citizens, civil society actors, and local communities in shaping public decisions and influencing outcomes. Participation is therefore not limited to consultation, but understood as an ongoing process through which state–society relations are negotiated and legitimacy is constructed. This is especially relevant in transitional contexts, where governance structures are often fragmented, contested, or in flux. In such settings, legitimacy is derived from formal authority as well as from the capacity of institutions to create inclusive spaces for engagement and public deliberation. During political transition, participation can thus become a key mechanism for renegotiating trust, accountability, and public legitimacy. Thomas Tufte highlights that participatory governance often emerges in response to gaps between institutions and citizens' demands. These dynamics can develop both from below, through mobilization and demands for inclusion, and from above, through institutional efforts to create participatory spaces and strengthen engagement (Tufte, 2017, p. 67). Participation is thus produced through ongoing interaction between citizens, institutions, and governance systems rather than formal structures alone.

In the Syrian context, participatory governance helps explain how citizens engage with emerging local governance structures during the transitional period. However, access and influence vary significantly depending on political, institutional, and social conditions. This framework therefore enables an analysis of how governance structures enable, constrain, or negotiate public participation within Syria's evolving transitional landscape.

3.4 Conceptual Framework

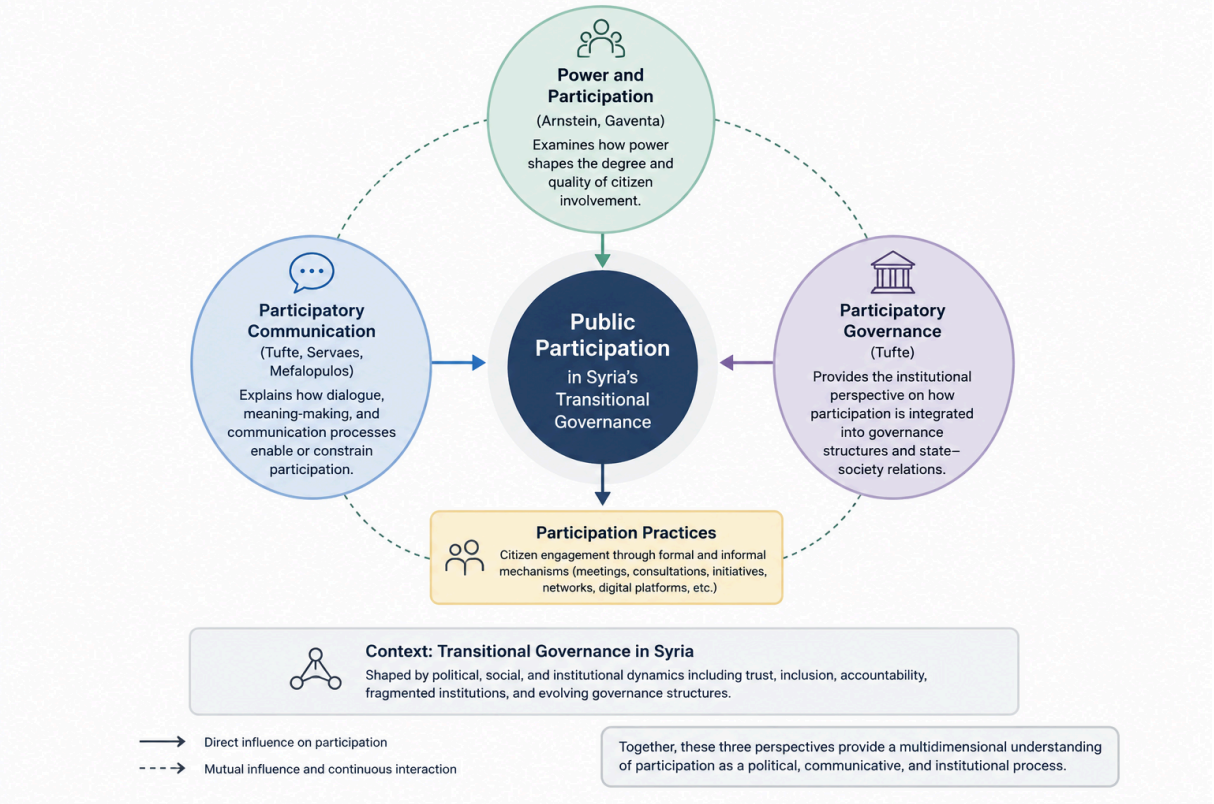


Figure 4 illustrates the relationship between these theoretical dimensions and demonstrates how public participation operates as a communicative process within Syria's transitional context.

Based on the theoretical perspectives outlined above, this study adopts a conceptual framework that understands public participation as a multidimensional process shaped through the interaction of power relations, communication practices, and governance structures. As illustrated in Figure 4, the framework places public participation at the center of the analysis and examines how it is influenced by three interconnected dimensions: power and participation, participatory communication, and participatory governance. The first dimension focuses on how influence is distributed within participatory processes and the extent to which citizens can shape decisions and outcomes, ranging from symbolic inclusion to substantive forms of participation. The second highlights the role of communication, dialogue, and meaning-making in enabling agency and engagement across formal and informal spaces, including community networks, civil society, and digital platforms. The third examines how participation is embedded within governance structures, particularly in transitional

contexts where legitimacy, accountability, and state–society relations are continuously shaped and reconfigured.

Chapter 4. Methodology

This chapter outlines the research design and approach used to examine shifting public participation in Syria after the collapse of the Assad regime. Given the complexity of transitional governance, the study adopts a qualitative, interpretivist approach to capture lived experiences, local meanings, and communicative practices. It focuses on how governance, voice, and institutional relations are shaped in practice through a multi-method design combining semi-structured interviews, document analysis, and discourse analysis.

Semi-structured interview

Semi-structured interviews were used in this study as the primary method of data collection, as they provide both structure and flexibility in exploring participants' experiences. As Lioness Ayres explains, semi-structured interviews involve a series of predetermined but open-ended questions, allowing the researcher to guide the discussion while giving participants the freedom to express their perspectives in their own terms (2012, p 811). This approach is particularly suitable for this study, as it enables an in-depth exploration of how individuals understand and experience participation in a complex and changing context.

To ensure consistency and depth in data collection, an interview guide was developed in advance, with questions designed in an open-ended manner to encourage detailed and reflective responses. At the same time, the flexible nature of this method made it possible to adapt the order of questions, ask follow-up probes, and explore emerging themes during the conversation. This helped generate rich qualitative data and allowed participants to elaborate on their experiences, meanings, and interpretations. The data collected through these interviews were later analysed using Sherry Arnstein's ladder of citizen participation as an analytical framework.

Furthermore, all interviews were conducted in Arabic, and the interview guide was also prepared in Arabic to ensure clarity, accessibility, and cultural relevance for participants. Each interview lasted between 30 and 60 minutes, depending on the participant's

availability and the depth of their responses. With participants' informed consent, all interviews were audio/video recorded through Microsoft Teams to ensure accuracy in data collection and analysis. Participants were selected through a combination of purposive and snowball sampling. Initial contacts were identified through existing personal, academic, and professional networks, including recommendations provided through academic contacts connected to the research topic. These initial contacts then referred to additional individuals with relevant experiences related to local governance, civil society, humanitarian work, and civic engagement. In several cases, interviewees further recommended other potential participants, creating a snowball effect that facilitated access to a broader network of respondents. This approach made it possible to access participants with relevant lived experiences while also ensuring diversity in perspectives across different regional, social, and professional backgrounds. The research initially aimed to conduct 16 interviews.

However, despite several follow-up attempts, one potential participant did not respond further, resulting in a final total of 15 completed interviews included in the study. Thus**,** the use of semi-structured interviews allowed for a collaborative process between us as researchers and the participants, where knowledge was co-produced through dialogue and shared reflection on lived experiences. This method was particularly effective in capturing nuanced accounts of how participation is understood and practiced in the Syrian context, especially in relation to local initiatives, civic activities, and interactions with institutions. It also enabled participants to express how communication shapes their engagement, the challenges they face, and the strategies they use to navigate complex and changing conditions.

Discourse analysis

Discourse analysis is used in this study to examine how participation and governance are constructed through language. As Jonathan Potter and Margaret Wetherell explain, it is "a cluster of related methods for studying language use and its role in social life" (2012, p. 218), highlighting that language actively shapes social reality rather than merely describing it. From this perspective, meanings of participation are continuously produced through communication, allowing the study to explore how individuals in post-conflict Syria interpret participation, express experiences, and position themselves in relation to institutions and authority.

Furthermore, discourse is closely linked to power and social structures. As Norman Fairclough (1995) argues, discourse plays a key role in reproducing power relations, meaning that representations of participation are shaped by broader social and political conditions. This enables the analysis to examine how participation is framed, legitimized, or constrained, focusing on both what is said and how it is said, including narratives and recurring linguistic patterns.

In addition, language is always embedded in context. As Potter and Wetherell (2012) note, discourse cannot be separated from its social and situational setting, which allows the study to capture how understandings of participation vary across contexts shaped by local conditions, political sensitivities, and lived experience. Different and sometimes competing discourses may coexist, where participation is framed as meaningful in some accounts and symbolic or limited in others, reflecting unequal power relations and access.

In summary, discourse analysis helps reveal how meanings and power relations are embedded in language by showing how participation is constructed, how certain voices are legitimized while others are marginalized, and how governance structures are reflected in everyday communication.

Document analysis:

Document analysis was used as a complementary method to examine how participation and governance are represented in written and visual materials. As Lindsay F. Prior explains, documents should not be seen as passive sources of information but as active elements in social life, describing them as “conduits of communication” containing meaningful messages (p. 231). This highlights their role in shaping social reality rather than simply reflecting it.

To this end, a range of materials was analysed, including policy documents, media coverage, participatory media formats, and international reports. For example, the UK government’s Country Policy and Information Note on Syria was used to provide an external perspective on political expression and state–citizen relations, while reporting by Al-Araby Al-Jadeed was examined to understand how protests and civic demands

are framed. In addition, participatory media such as Salon Al-Jumhuriya on Syria Now was analysed as mediated public engagement, alongside digital platforms like Instagram as spaces for visual narratives and alternative expression. At the institutional level, documents such as the Citizen Budget 2026 (Syrian Ministry of Finance) and the Code of Professional and Ethical Conduct for the Media Sector (Syrian Ministry of Information) were reviewed to assess official narratives on transparency, ethics, and access to information. International sources, including Reporters Without Borders rankings and analyses from The Economist and Enab Baladi, were also included to situate these representations within broader external evaluations.

Methodologically, the analysis was aligned with the discourse approach, focusing on recurring themes, narratives, and representations of participation across materials. Accordingly, similarities and tensions between institutional claims and lived experiences were identified. Moreover, context was treated as central, as documents were understood as embedded in social practices shaped by their production, audience, and circulation. This approach shows how certain forms of participation are legitimized while others are marginalised.

Finally, document analysis strengthens the study by complementing interviews and discourse analysis, enabling a more comprehensive understanding of how participation is communicated, represented, and institutionalised across different sources.

4.1 Case Study Approach

This study adopts a multiple case study approach to examine how public participation is shaped across different local governance contexts in Syria. This design is appropriate because participation in transitional settings is uneven and varies according to governance structures, institutional capacity, security conditions, and local social dynamics. Accordingly, the study applies a maximum variation sampling strategy to capture different governance configurations and identify both shared patterns and contextual differences. Rather than treating Syria as a uniform setting, it focuses on distinct local realities where participation is constructed differently in practice.

The selected cases include; Damascus and Rural Damascus, Northwest Syria (Idlib and Aleppo) and Northeast Syria (Hasakah and Deir ez-Zor). This comparative design

enables analysis of how participation, legitimacy, and communication practices vary across institutional contexts. Hence, the study focuses on mechanisms and relationships rather than statistical generalisation, generating analytical insights into how participation operates under different governance conditions in Syria's transitional landscape.

4.2 Data Collection Methods

This study uses multiple qualitative methods to develop a context-sensitive understanding of public participation in Syria's transitional governance settings. Accordingly, methodological triangulation is applied to enhance credibility by cross-checking insights across different data sources.

The primary method is semi-structured interviews, selected for their flexibility in exploring key themes while allowing participants to articulate their own experiences in depth. This is particularly suitable for sensitive and complex topics such as governance transition and civic engagement. Participants include citizens, community members, local governance actors, and civil society representatives, ensuring a range of perspectives on participation across institutional and community levels. Additionally, document analysis is used to examine reports, policy texts, organizational communication, and publicly available materials from governance and civil society actors. This helps situate interview data and shows how participation is formally framed and communicated.

Moreover, discourse analysis is applied to media content, institutional statements, and public messaging to explore how participation is constructed and narrated in public space. This is especially relevant in transitional contexts where competing narratives about legitimacy and governance may exist. These methods allow the study to link lived experiences with institutional and discursive representations, while strengthening analytical depth through triangulation.

4.3 Sampling Strategy

This study employs a purposive sampling strategy in order to select participants who are directly involved in or affected by processes of public participation and local governance within the selected Syrian contexts. Purposive sampling is appropriate for

qualitative research where the aim is not statistical generalization, but rather in-depth understanding of social processes, meanings, and lived experiences. Participants are selected based on their relevance to the research questions, this includes individuals who have experience in facilitating, negotiating, or observing participation processes at the local level.

The sampling strategy aims to ensure diversity in perspectives across different governance environments, including formal institutional actors, community leaders (such as neighbourhood or village leader “mukhtars“ and local representatives), and actors working within civil society or humanitarian organizations. This allows for capturing variations in how participation is practiced and understood across different settings.

Furthermore, access to participants is primarily facilitated through professional networks, organizational contacts, and snowball sampling, where initial respondents recommend additional relevant participants. Given the sensitivity of the Syrian context and the political nature of participation, snowball sampling is particularly useful for reaching individuals who may not be easily accessible through formal channels.

The final sample size is flexible and guided by the principle of data saturation, meaning data collection continues until no new significant insights emerge in relation to the research questions.

4.4 Ethical Considerations

This study addresses politically sensitive topics related to governance and participation in a post-conflict setting. Accordingly, ethical considerations are central throughout the research process and follow Malmö University’s ethical guidelines and ComDev research principles. All participants were informed about the purpose of the study, the voluntary nature of participation, and their right to withdraw at any time. Consent was obtained prior to interviews, either verbally or in writing depending on the communication format. Moreover, confidentiality and anonymity were carefully protected due to the sensitivity of the Syrian context. Identifying details were removed or anonymised during transcription and reporting, and pseudonyms were used where necessary. Since participants could face social, professional, or political risks, data was

securely stored on password-protected devices accessible only to the research team, while audio recordings were deleted after transcription and verification.

The study also followed the principle of avoiding harm by approaching sensitive topics carefully and allowing participants to skip questions or redirect conversations when needed. In addition, researcher reflexivity remained important throughout the process, particularly given the researchers' cultural and contextual proximity to the field. Therefore, continuous reflection was used to reduce bias and maintain analytical transparency.

4.5 Validity, Reliability, and Generalizability

To strengthen the credibility of the study, findings were developed through triangulation by comparing insights from the 15 semi-structured interviews with policy documents, international reports, and media discourse. This helped reduce reliance on single sources and supported a more balanced interpretation of participation and governance practices. In addition, methodological transparency was maintained through the use of standardized interview guides (Appendix C) and a structured data overview matrix (Appendix D) documenting the research process and data management.

Given the fluid and localized nature of transitional governance in Syria, the study does not aim for statistical generalization. Instead, it seeks analytical transferability by relating the findings to broader theoretical frameworks such as Arnstein's ladder and Gaventa's power spaces. Accordingly, the study contributes conceptual insights into participation, legitimacy, and governance that may also be relevant for understanding public engagement in other post-conflict or post-authoritarian contexts.

4.6 Limitations

This study has several limitations that should be considered when interpreting the findings. Access to participants and local contexts was affected by geographical dispersion and ongoing instability in parts of Syria, which limited engagement with some governance actors and communities. Consequently, the study may not capture the full range of participation practices across all regions.

Second, the political sensitivity surrounding governance and public participation in a post-conflict environment may have influenced participant responses. Some participants may have exercised caution or self-censorship when discussing their experiences. In addition, the study relies primarily on interviews and secondary materials, which provide insight into perceptions and representations rather than direct observation of all participatory processes.

A further limitation concerns the use of Arnstein's Ladder as an analytical framework. While the model offers a valuable lens for examining power and influence, it was developed within a Western institutional context and does not fully account for the informal, relational, and digitally mediated forms of participation observed in Syria. As such, the framework should be understood as a heuristic rather than a definitive measure of participation. Complementary perspectives, such as hybrid governance, informal institutions, and everyday politics, help address this gap but cannot entirely resolve the conceptual challenges of studying participation in transitional and authoritarian settings.

Finally, the research focuses on a specific transitional period following major political change. Governance arrangements and participatory practices in Syria continue to evolve, and the relatively short timeframe of the study limits the ability to assess longer-term trajectories. The findings should therefore be interpreted as a snapshot of an ongoing and fluid process rather than a conclusive assessment of Syria's participatory landscape.

Chapter 5. Empirical Findings

This chapter presents the empirical findings of the study, drawing on qualitative data collected through 15 semi-structured interviews with participants involved in local governance, civil society, humanitarian work, and community activism across different regions in Syria (Damascus, Rural Damascus, Northeast Syria and Northwest Syria).

The analysis reveals that participation in the Syrian transitional context is not structured through a single, formalized system. Instead, it operates through a highly fragmented and hybridized landscape. The findings are structured into four thematic areas: forms of participation and regional variations, citizen-institution interaction, communication practices and digital informality, and emerging governance dynamics.

5.1 Forms of Participation: Stratification and Regional Variation

Understanding participation in contemporary Syria requires moving beyond the assumption of a unified national framework and instead recognizing the emergence of multiple, coexisting governance systems, each producing its own logic of participation. The analysis from this study suggests that participation is uneven across regions and structurally differentiated, influenced by varying local governance arrangements, institutional capacities, and evolving political and security contexts.

5.1.1 Damascus and Rural Damascus

In Damascus and its rural surroundings, participation unfolds within a system that can be described as centralized hybridity, where the state continues to occupy the core of authority while selectively opening limited spaces for civil society engagement. However, the empirical accounts from participants suggest that this hybridity is institutional and deeply shaped by historical legacies, evolving local dynamics, and the adaptive strategies of both citizens and authorities in a post-conflict setting.

Participants consistently emphasized that their involvement rarely extends beyond implementation, reinforcing the distinction between participation as presence and participation as influence. Samia's characterization of her role as an "executive partnership, not a partnership in decision-making" reflects a broader structural reality in which civil society actors are mobilized to execute projects but remain excluded from agenda-setting processes. This indicates that while participation is formally encouraged, it is substantively constrained, maintaining the state's dominance over strategic decisions.

Yet, the interview with Rafee adds an important layer of nuance to this picture by revealing that participation in Rural Damascus - particularly in areas like Al-Kisweh - cannot be fully understood through a state-centric lens alone. Rafee's experience highlights the emergence of locally driven forms of participation that operate in parallel to, and sometimes independently from, formal state structures. He explains that, especially in the period following institutional collapse, "most initiatives are community-driven rather than state-led," with local actors mobilizing resources,

organizing services, and addressing urgent needs without relying on governmental capacity. This highlights that participation increasingly emerges through locally initiated practices that create alternative spaces for collective action outside formal institutional structures.

At the same time, the participants' account reinforces the argument that even when participation expands in practice, it does not necessarily translate into structured or institutionalized influence. While they describe instances of consultation, such as being approached for advice on local initiatives or maintaining informal communication channels with municipal leaders. These interactions remain highly personalized and contingent on social capital rather than embedded within formal participatory mechanisms. Influence, in this sense, is unequally distributed and relational, shaped by reputation, trust, and networks rather than guaranteed by institutional design.

This reliance on informal channels is further illustrated by Rafee's description of initiatives such as the "Families Council" in Al-Kisweh, a locally initiated structure aimed at representing community interests. Although the council gradually gained legitimacy and began to influence certain local decisions, including leadership selection and coordination with authorities, its emergence was not the result of formal decentralization policies but rather a grassroots response to governance gaps. This underscores a key paradox: while participatory structures may exist or emerge, their effectiveness depends less on formal recognition and more on social acceptance and practical utility.

Simultaneously, bureaucratic constraints continue to shape the limits of participation within more formalized sectors, particularly through approval procedures that are often justified by security concerns. However, humanitarian initiatives are generally easier to initiate with fewer obstacles. As Haid (2026) notes in his article after transition, "Humanitarian activities..., street clean-ups, food distribution, medical aid, generally proceed unhindered." Nevertheless, Samya and Aya's experiences within humanitarian structures linked to official institutions demonstrate how community needs are still filtered through administrative hierarchies. Even when needs are clearly identified at the local level, the capacity to respond remains subject to approval processes that reinforce central control. Participation therefore becomes mediated through institutional

procedures that prioritize order, oversight, and security considerations over responsiveness.

Another critical dimension emerging from other participants' accounts is the persistence of socio-cultural barriers to participation. Participants explicitly point to a "legacy of fear" and a deeply ingrained culture of passivity, where individuals hesitate to express opinions or take initiative due to long-standing experiences of repression. Although participants acknowledge that this is gradually changing, with more (youth) engaging in community work and forming volunteer groups, As Servaes argues, "cultures are not homogeneous and bounded entities, but rather dynamic, heterogeneous and open-ended" (2021, p. 52- 53). This perspective helps explain how younger generations are gradually reshaping participatory practices through volunteer groups and community initiatives despite enduring fear and institutional constraints.

They stressed that this transformation is slow and unbalanced. Participation is increasing in quantity, but not yet fully in quality or sustainability. Moreover, Rafee highlights an additional challenge that complicates participatory practices: the personalization of engagement. He observes that many individuals participate not out of a sense of collective responsibility, but due to trust in specific individuals. As he explains, attendance and engagement often depend on who initiates an activity rather than the activity itself. This indicates that participation is still embedded in interpersonal dynamics rather than institutionalized civic norms, limiting its scalability and long-term impact. This is compounded by material constraints, as economic hardship significantly restricts citizens' ability to engage. Participants note that for many, daily survival takes precedence over civic participation, leaving limited time or energy for sustained involvement in community initiatives. Participation, therefore, becomes episodic and reactive, often driven by urgency or personal motivation rather than continuous engagement.

At the perceptual level, participants also pointed to a persistent gap between citizens and formal institutions. Farah's description of decision-making as "chaotic" and disconnected from real consultation reflects a broader skepticism toward the effectiveness of participatory spaces. Even when opportunities for engagement exist, they are often perceived as symbolic rather than impactful, reinforcing feelings of marginalization among youth and other social groups.

Taken together, the case of Damascus and Rural Damascus reveals a complex and evolving participatory landscape. On the one hand, centralized authority continues to structure the boundaries of formal participation, limiting civil society's role to implementation and reinforcing bureaucratic control. On the other hand, the weakening of state capacity has opened space for locally driven initiatives that partially reconfigure participation from below. However, these emerging forms remain fragmented, informal, and heavily dependent on social relations, lacking the institutional support necessary for sustained influence.

Participation in this context, therefore, cannot be understood simply as present or absent. Rather, it exists as a layered and negotiated process, shaped by the interaction between enduring centralization, emerging local agency, the socio-economic and cultural conditions that enable or constrain citizen engagement.

5.1.2 Northwest Syria (Idlib/Aleppo)

In Northwest Syria, the dynamics of participation have undergone significant transformation over time, particularly in relation to shifts in governing authorities, institutional arrangements, and the broader reconfiguration of local governance structures. Rather than existing as a fully fragmented space, participation in this context can be understood as emerging within an evolving hybrid system - one that combines formal and semi-formal consultation mechanisms with increasing institutional centralization at higher administrative levels.

As Yasin explained, during the earlier phase following the establishment of transitional governance structures around 2019, participation was more visibly embedded in local decision-making processes. Smaller-scale councils, including family councils and local representative bodies, played a more active role in mediating between communities and governance actors. According to his account, these structures allowed residents to engage in discussions and, in some cases, directly influence or adjust local decisions. Participation during this period was therefore more closely linked to immediate community needs and retained a clearer connection to localized governance practices.

However, participants consistently emphasized that this model has gradually changed. With the increasing consolidation of governance structures and a stronger orientation toward national-level coordination, decision-making processes have become more centralized.

Yasin noted that this shift has reduced the space for local influence, as priorities are now more frequently defined at higher administrative levels rather than through localized consultation processes. While local councils and community-based structures still exist in some form, their capacity to meaningfully shape decisions has become more limited compared to earlier phases. As a result, participation in the current context is more structured but less directly influential. It is increasingly mediated through formal institutional channels that emphasize coordination, service delivery, and administrative efficiency rather than direct community negotiation. This creates a situation in which citizens may still be consulted or informed, but their ability to meaningfully alter or reshape decisions is more constrained than before.

Tariq also highlighted this shift, emphasizing that the current governance environment has moved away from decentralized consultation toward more hierarchical decision-making structures. He pointed out that while participation mechanisms still exist, they are often integrated into pre-defined institutional frameworks that limit the extent of bottom-up influence. In his view, this has led to a form of participation that is more procedural than substantive, where engagement exists but does not necessarily translate into decision-making power. Within this changing landscape, NGO actors continue to play a significant role in facilitating participation, particularly in humanitarian and reconstruction-related sectors. Mahmoud and Tariq, explained that NGOs often represent the main entry point for community engagement, especially through project-based consultation mechanisms and feedback processes. However, they also noted that these forms of participation remain sector-specific and do not extend into broader governance structures, reinforcing a clear separation between participation in service delivery and participation in policy formation.

At the community level, participation often takes place through consultative processes that vary depending on context and urgency. Mahmoud described how, in some cases, broad community consultations are conducted, while in others participation is more selective due to operational constraints: “Sometimes we gather people and hear everyone’s opinion… but depending on the situation, you cannot always include everyone”. This reflects the practical limitations of participatory processes in environments characterized by resource constraints and urgent service delivery needs. He further illustrated this through examples such as municipal waste management, where community input has been used to inform decisions like increasing waste containers or improving service delivery. In such cases, participation is not merely symbolic; however, it is filtered through considerations of feasibility, urgency,

and institutional capacity rather than constituting a direct decision-making mechanism. At the same time, participants emphasized that participation is often mediated through emerging governance structures such as family councils, local councils or community representatives. These bodies function as intermediaries between citizens and governing authorities, reflecting a hybrid governance arrangement in which decision-making is partially decentralized but still constrained by broader administrative hierarchies. As Mahmoud explained: “We are trying to build a link between the people and the state institutions… but there is still confusion in roles and responsibilities”. This statement highlights a central feature of participation in Northwest Syria: it is not absent, but rather inconsistently institutionalized and heavily dependent on intermediary actors, informal networks, and varying levels of organizational capacity.

In addition, participants pointed to the continued importance of local notables, elders, and community representatives in facilitating communication between residents and authorities, particularly in areas where formal governance structures remain weak or under development. These actors often serve as informal channels for negotiation, mediation, and conflict resolution, especially in situations requiring urgent community-level responses. Despite these limitations, participants also noted that localized forms of engagement still exist and, in some cases, have become more visible in recent years. However, as Mahmoud and Tariq both suggested, these forms of participation are increasingly shaped by institutional priorities and operational constraints, resulting in participation that is more consultative than decisional in nature.

Overall, participation in Northwest Syria reflects a transitional governance environment in which earlier, more localized and community-driven decision-making spaces have been partially replaced by more centralized and structured systems. While opportunities for engagement continue to exist - particularly through NGOs, local councils, and informal community structures - their influence over decision-making processes has become more limited as governance has progressively shifted toward national-level coordination and institutional consolidation.

5.1.3 Northeast Syria (Al-Hasakah / Deir Ez-Zor)

“I make spring so others can walk in its gardens.”
Dr. Samar, Syrian Medical Association

Northeast Syria presents a complex configuration of participation, often linked to localized governance structures such as neighborhood committees (“Comités”). While

these mechanisms are formally designed to facilitate community involvement and bring decision-making closer to the local level, participants' accounts suggest a more limited and inconsistent reality in practice. Rather than functioning as fully participatory spaces, these structures tend to operate primarily as channels for managing everyday service-related issues.

Participants such as Nozad indicated that individuals can, to some extent, raise concerns and engage in discussions within these local forums, particularly around basic needs such as water, electricity, and infrastructure. However, this engagement is often confined to lower-level administrative matters and does not necessarily translate into broader influence over governance processes. As a result, while these committees create a degree of localized interaction between citizens and authorities, they do not fundamentally alter the distribution of decision-making power. Instead, they offer a limited form of participation that remains bounded within predefined institutional and political constraints. However, this apparent inclusivity must be understood within the broader political transformation that has taken place in the region. As several participants highlighted, the beginning of the year marked a significant shift, with the announcement of an agreement between the new central government and the Autonomous Administration alongside the Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF). While this agreement formally signaled a process of integration, participants consistently emphasized that this integration remains largely symbolic at the institutional level. In practice, decision-making authority continues to be concentrated within the structures of the Autonomous Administration and SDF.

Dr. Saad, for instance, noted that while "military integration has been almost fully completed," institutional governance has not undergone a comparable transformation. Civil and administrative structures, as he and others explained, remain firmly under the control of the Autonomous Administration. This creates a dual-layered governance reality, in which formal narratives of unification coexist with the continued dominance of existing power structures, limiting any meaningful redistribution of authority or expansion of participatory influence at the political level. Within this context, participation through local committees becomes inherently limited. While these structures allow for engagement at the micro-level, their influence rarely extends beyond immediate service-related issues. As Dr. Saad explained, the system remains "incomplete" and lacks the institutional coherence necessary to connect local input with

higher-level decision-making processes. This fragmentation effectively isolates participation within narrow administrative domains, preventing it from evolving into meaningful political influence.

At the same time, the persistence of fear and insecurity continues to shape participatory practices in profound ways. Participants repeatedly referred to ongoing concerns related to surveillance and the possibility of detention, which constrain individuals' willingness to express dissenting views or engage critically with governance structures. Participants explicitly linked weak participation to a "continued fear of arrest," while others echoed similar concerns, indicating that the political environment remains risky despite formal shifts toward integration. A particularly illustrative example of the limits of participation and political expression comes from Hasakah, where one participant described how a young person asked his mother to bring the new Syrian flag from Damascus following political changes. However, she felt compelled to hide the flag due to fear of arrest or repercussions. This incident reflects a broader tension between symbolic political alignment and the lived reality of insecurity. As several participants noted, many people may formally support the new government, yet continue to conceal their political attitudes or expressions due to uncertainty about potential consequences.

Dr. Samar's reflections further illuminate this tension between form and substance. While she acknowledged that participatory spaces exist, she emphasized that social and political pressures continue to define the boundaries of what can be said and who can speak. Participation, in this sense, is not only shaped by institutional design but also by deeply embedded cultures of fear and uncertainty, which limit the depth and authenticity of engagement. This combination of formal inclusion, constrained authority, and persistent fear produces what can be understood as a controlled participatory environment. On the surface, structures exist to facilitate representation and community input. Yet, in practice, centralized decision-making remains intact, and participation is confined to low-stakes domains that do not challenge existing power arrangements.

At the same time, similar dynamics appear in Deir Ez-Zor, where participation is increasingly shaped by a mixture of local committees, NGOs, and emerging administrative structures following recent political changes. As highlighted in Nour's interview, access to information and engagement with local initiatives has become more flexible compared to previous periods, with fewer security restrictions and greater

operational space for civil society actors. In this context, NGOs are generally able to operate relatively smoothly across Deir Ez-Zor and wider Northeast Syria, in ways that participants described as administratively comparable to conditions in Damascus, despite ongoing structural limitations and unequal governance capacities. However, participation in Deir Ez-Zor remains inconsistent and politically conditioned. While humanitarian and development activities may function with greater procedural ease, influence over priorities and decision-making is still mediated through local intermediaries and administrative actors, rather than emerging from direct community-driven governance structures. A notable example of public contention in Deir Ez-Zor involved protests against a government-backed project to construct a large religious complex in place of a public park. The incident escalated after widespread criticism on social media, eventually leading to the symbolic destruction of the foundation stone and the removal of official inscriptions. This reflects how, when formal participatory channels are perceived as ineffective or insufficient, public expression can shift into more visible and confrontational forms, particularly through digital mobilization and street-level action.

As a result, Northeast Syria exemplifies a particularly complex form of participatory governance: one in which institutional mechanisms of inclusion coexist with structural limitations, uneven regional dynamics, and persistent political control, leading to a situation where participation is present, but its transformative potential remains significantly restricted.

5.2 Citizen–Institution Interaction and the 'Trust Gap'

Interactions between citizens and institutions in the Syrian context are complex and often characterized by limited direct engagement with formal state structures. Communication and participation are frequently mediated through intermediary actors such as NGOs, Mukhtars (neighbourhood or village leader), tribal/local community leaders and religious actors, who play an important role in connecting citizens with governance and service-related processes. Interactions between citizens and Civil society organizations, particularly NGOs and INGOs, have become significant facilitators of citizen participation at the local level. Nour, who has extensive humanitarian work experience in Northeast Syria (Deir Ez-Zor), illustrated this divide between community-level influence and formal political authority: “I can influence

decisions at the community level or within my organization... but my influence on governmental decisions is almost non-existent." This reflects how opportunities for participation are often more accessible within the "invited spaces" described by Andrea Cornwall (2002), where humanitarian and civil society actors create channels for consultation and engagement. However, citizens' ability to influence formal governmental decision-making processes remains highly constrained. Some participants also noted that certain institutions have recently introduced complaint and feedback mechanisms that allow citizens to report concerns and communicate directly with public authorities. These initiatives were described as attempts to increase responsiveness and improve communication between institutions and local communities.

A recurring theme across interviews is the deep-seated lack of trust between citizens and formal institutions. Basheer and other participants pointed out that despite recent attempts by some institutions to build transparent, participatory models (e.g., digital feedback mechanisms), progress is severely hindered by a historical trust deficit spanning decades. "People are not used to institutions genuinely listening to them," he noted. Consequently, citizens often bypass formal complaints mechanisms, preferring to rely on personal networks or public pressure. In this context, communication becomes central to sustaining participation and rebuilding institutional trust. As Servaes notes, "where people have options to change their ways of life, communication becomes important in informing, persuading, listening, data gathering, educating, training, and managing change" (2021, p. 112). This helps explain why NGOs and local intermediaries have become key actors in facilitating citizen engagement in the absence of trusted state institutions.

5.3 Communication Practices and Digital Informality

Viewed through the lens of Communication for Social Change (CFSC), the data indicates that interaction between state institutions and citizens does not primarily occur through standardized or fully institutionalized communication systems. Rather, communication practices are dispersed across multiple channels, where formal mechanisms operate alongside digital platforms and intermediary networks. In this context, "digital informality" has become the dominant mode through which information circulates and participation is negotiated in everyday practice.

A recurring theme across all interviews - regardless of geography - was the overwhelming reliance on digital platforms, particularly Facebook, Instagram, Telegram, and WhatsApp, as primary spaces for both information access and civic participation. Yasin noted that economic decisions and local policies are often circulated via Facebook pages and local WhatsApp groups long before any official announcement. Building on this, the interview with Mahmoud from Aleppo illustrates that participation in Northwest Syria today is still present, but it operates through more hybrid and informal channels, particularly mediated by digital platforms and local intermediaries. He explains that access to information about public decisions and local initiatives is primarily shaped by social media platforms: “The main source now is Facebook and social media… and WhatsApp groups for news, even if they are not official”. Some participants also noted that NGOs use the same digital platforms to communicate with formal institutions. Samia explained, for example, that WhatsApp groups are used to maintain direct communication channels with ministries such as the Ministry of Culture, where information about new initiatives and activities is shared and coordinated. This illustrates how informal digital networks have become practical tools for facilitating coordination between civil society actors and governmental institutions. For many citizens, social media has become the only viable platform for expressing grievances. Mahmoud explained that public outcry on Facebook frequently forces local municipalities to reverse unpopular decisions, acting as an informal veto power. These findings indicate that participation is closely tied to communication flows, where access to information and the ability to respond or influence decisions are shaped through digital and informal channels rather than formal institutional structures alone. While these communication channels expand opportunities for participation and interaction, they also reshape how information is produced, circulated, and interpreted within society.

However, participants also emphasized the dual role of social media in this communicative landscape. While digital platforms serve as important spaces for accessing information, expressing opinions, and voicing criticism, they are simultaneously vulnerable to the spread of disinformation and misleading content. Hani, an activist in Al-Hasakah, highlighted that the digital space is highly polarized and affected by what he described as an “infodemic,” where the absence of a unified and trusted information source contributes to the amplification of rumours, hate speech, and

social divisions. Similarly, Dr. Saad noted that although online engagement is intense, the lack of effective regulatory or institutional frameworks often turns these platforms into unstable arenas rather than structured spaces for democratic deliberation. For instance, Hamren, from Hasakah mentioned that when she visited Damascus, she realized that many of the exaggerations and alarming narratives circulating on social media did not reflect the reality on the ground, highlighting, in many cases, a gap between online portrayals and lived experience.

5.4 Emerging Governance Dynamics and the Post-Authoritarian Legacy

Governance in transitional Syria is characterized by hybridity, where formal state actors, local administrations, civil society organizations, and humanitarian actors increasingly interact within evolving governance structures aimed at rebuilding public institutions and expanding civic engagement. However, one of the most significant findings regarding governance is the enduring psychological and social legacy of authoritarianism.

Even when formal security constraints have loosened, participants described the continued presence of what can be understood as "invisible power," where the long-term social legacy of authoritarian governance continues to shape everyday interactions and public expression. Decades of fear, self-censorship, and distrust have become embedded within social relations, meaning that barriers to participation are no longer exclusively political but increasingly social and cultural. Farah articulated this vividly: "The problem with expressing opinions is not the authorities. The community itself confiscates opposing opinions. Anyone different is treated as an enemy." Similarly, Samar noted that while people feel freer to complain about services online, "social and political fear still dictates what can be said and who can say it." As a result, these internalized patterns continue to affect the development of constructive civic dialogue and inclusive public debate even after political change.

Despite these constraints, participants described a noticeable shift in the social and political atmosphere compared to previous periods. Aya (Rural Damascus) and other participants referred to a transition from a "fear-based society" toward a more participation-oriented environment. Volunteerism, youth initiatives, and a growing sense of local ownership ("this is our country") were frequently described as increasingly

visible. As Tariq (Idlib) summarized: “Initiatives are now driven by the community, not the state. We are transitioning from being influenced by subjects to influencing actors.”

Participants also highlighted significant changes in opportunities for public expression, emphasizing that individuals are increasingly able to criticize government actions and institutional performance publicly without fear of arrest or immediate legal repercussions. Most of the participants pointed out that demonstrations and public protests have become more visible means of expressing dissatisfaction with laws, policies, and public services. These developments reflect an expansion of civic space in which public critique, negotiation, and participation are more socially and politically possible than in earlier periods.

Overall, the empirical findings suggest that while opportunities for participation have expanded in post-conflict Syria, decision-making power remains unevenly distributed across institutional and political structures. Citizens therefore navigate a complex environment shaped by evolving governance arrangements, digital informality, and persistent social constraints, where participation is simultaneously enabled and limited across different communicative and institutional spaces.

Chapter 6. Analysis and Discussion

This chapter discusses the results in relation to the theoretical framework presented in Chapter 3. Drawing on Arnstein’s theory of participation, participatory communication approaches developed by Thomas Tufte and Paolo Mefalopulos, and broader perspectives on participatory governance and CFSC, the chapter analyzes how participation in Syria’s transitional context is shaped through the interaction of power relations, communication practices, institutional structures, and local agency.

The discussion demonstrates that participation in Syria is currently characterized by hybridity and negotiation rather than fully institutionalized democratic inclusion.While opportunities for public expression, civic engagement, and local mobilization have expanded significantly following the fall of the Assad regime, meaningful influence over governance and decision-making remains inconsistently distributed and highly dependent on local political and institutional conditions.

6.1 Climbing the Ladder or Reaching New Spaces? Participation and Power in Transitional Syria

Participation in transitional Syria presents a more complex and fluid landscape than Arnstein's Ladder of Citizen Participation alone can capture. While the model provides a useful starting point for examining power relations and degrees of citizen influence, the findings of this study show that participation across the country rarely moves beyond the levels of informing, consultation, and limited partnership. Full delegated power or citizen control remains largely absent. Yet, unlike previous periods under the Assad regime, the transitional phase has opened new spaces for civic expression and public engagement that would previously have been unthinkable.

Across Damascus, Northwest Syria, and parts of Northeast Syria, participants described a noticeable expansion in citizens' ability to publicly express opinions, criticize local authorities, and engage in protests and civic initiatives with reduced levels of fear compared to the pre-transition period. Demonstrations, local mobilizations, and online criticism increasingly occur without the severe security repercussions that once defined political life. Viewed through Arnstein's framework, this shift represents movement away from complete exclusion and repression toward forms of consultation, visibility, and limited negotiation. Participation in Syria today is therefore not static tokenism; it is an unstable and evolving process in which spaces for engagement are expanding unevenly across regions.

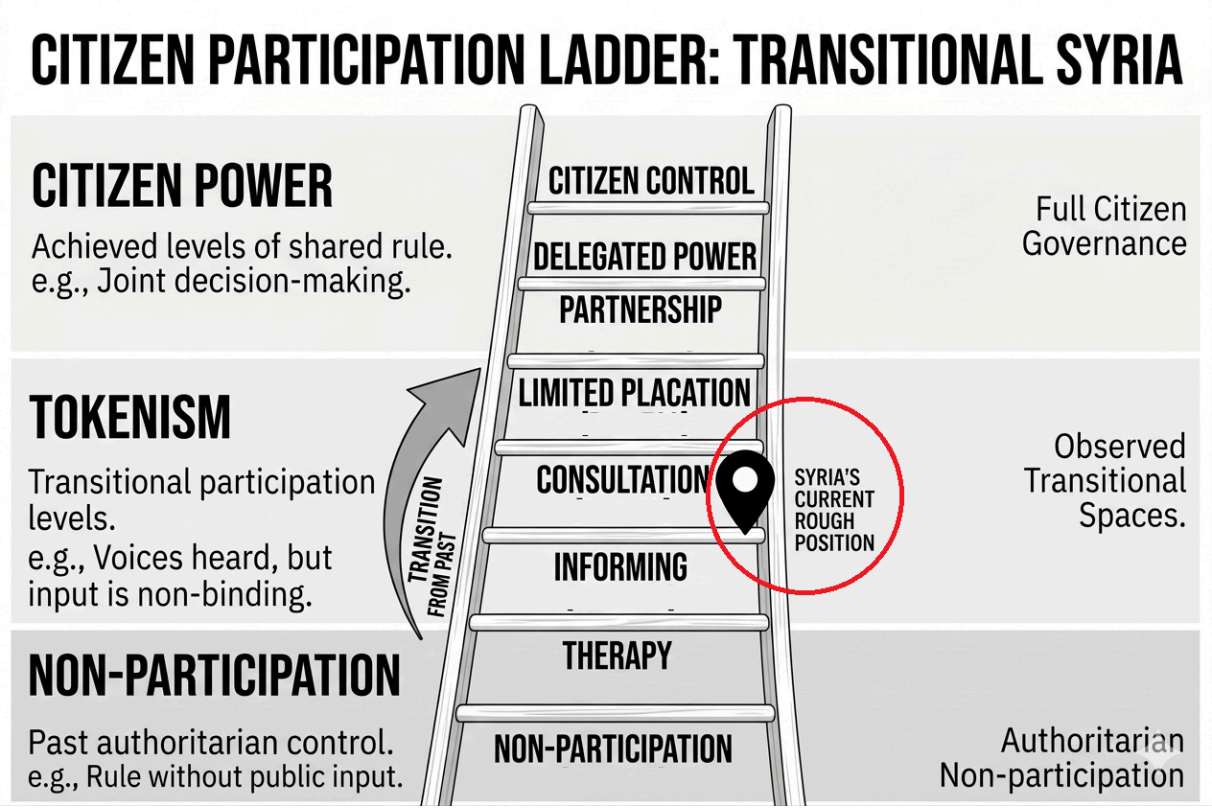


Figure 5 shows the levels of citizen participation in transitional Syria, ranging from non-participation to citizen power, with Syria currently positioned at the consultation stage.

At the same time, these participatory gains remain constrained by centralized institutional structures and multilayered governance arrangements. In Damascus and parts of Northwest Syria, authorities continue to control major policy directions and governance agendas, even when local consultation mechanisms exist. As a result, participation often remains mediated, conditional, and shaped by the priorities of those in power rather than fully citizen-driven. Importantly, consultation in the Syrian context does not operate through formal, institutionalized channels as Arnstein envisioned. Instead, it frequently occurs through personal networks, community intermediaries, informal negotiations, and digital communication platforms. These practices resemble consultation in terms of limited influence, yet they unfold in participatory spaces that are relational, hybrid, and shaped by post-conflict realities. An important exception concerns Al-Hasakah and parts of Northeast Syria, where political and institutional integration remains incomplete. Participants emphasized that governance fragmentation and unresolved political arrangements create uncertainty regarding representation, legitimacy, and public inclusion. While some spaces for civic participation exist, engagement in these areas remains more cautious, inconsistent, and dependent on shifting political dynamics.

Overall, the findings suggest that Syria's transitional participation landscape is best understood as a negotiated and hybrid process in which old authoritarian structures coexist with emerging forms of public engagement and local agency. Citizens navigate multiple authorities, shifting power centers, and unevenly distributed opportunities for expression and influence.

Rethinking Participation Beyond Arnstein

The findings of this study indicate that participation in post-conflict Syria cannot be fully understood through Arnstein's institutional and hierarchical model. Instead, participation emerges through hybrid governance arrangements, informal institutions, everyday political practices, and digitally mediated forms of engagement. These perspectives highlight how citizens navigate multiple authorities, rely on personal networks, and use digital platforms to influence public debates in contexts where formal participatory mechanisms are weak or distrusted. Such approaches offer more context-sensitive ways of understanding participation in transitional and authoritarian settings, complementing and extending Arnstein's framework rather than replacing it.

6.2 Participatory Governance Between Institutional Control and Civic Expansion

The findings strongly reflect the participatory governance perspective outlined in Chapter 3 by illustrating how governance legitimacy in transitional Syria is increasingly negotiated through interaction between citizens, local institutions, civil society actors, and communication networks rather than through centralized state authority alone. Across the interviews, participants described how local councils, municipalities, civil society organizations, and informal community actors increasingly function as intermediaries between citizens and governance institutions. As Thomas Tufte argues, "participatory governance took hold first as a top-down process, but increasingly in reverse order, as bottom-up processes" (2017, p. 75). This reflects a form of governance shaped through interaction and negotiation between institutions and communities rather than through top-down state control alone.

At the same time, participation remains highly unequally distributed and shaped by local power dynamics. NGO-led consultations, local committees, and participatory workshops often create opportunities for dialogue and civic engagement, yet access to

these spaces is not equally distributed. Participants repeatedly highlighted how individuals with professional backgrounds, NGO experience, or stronger social networks are more likely to participate in governance-related discussions than marginalized groups or ordinary citizens. This demonstrates how participation may formally expand while substantive influence remains concentrated among specific actors.

The findings also indicate that local governance actors increasingly recognize the importance of public responsiveness and visible engagement. Examples discussed in media coverage by Al-Araby Al-Jadeed illustrate how public demonstrations and civic protests are now more openly tolerated and, in some cases, even protected by local security actors. In several reported cases, public security forces were deployed not to suppress protests, but to secure demonstrations and prevent violence against protesters. Such developments represent a major symbolic shift compared to earlier authoritarian practices where demonstrations were routinely criminalized and violently suppressed. As Haid mentioned " These shifts represent a significant departure from the restrictive civic environment that defined the Assad era" (2025, p. 12)

This expansion of civic visibility is also reflected in recent institutional efforts aimed at improving transparency and communication. The Syrian Ministry of Finance introduced the Citizen Budget 2026 as an attempt to communicate public financial information more openly to citizens, while the Syrian Ministry of Information released the Code of Professional and Ethical Conduct for the Media Sector emphasizing media ethics, public communication, and access to information. Although the practical implementation and independence of these initiatives remain debated, their emergence nonetheless reflects an evolving governance discourse that increasingly incorporates participation, communication, and public accountability. This aligns with Gaventa's (2011) argument that sustainable modalities of participatory governance can be established through the state's attempts to develop new forms of expression. However, the results also demonstrate that participatory governance in Syria remains incomplete and fragile. Decision-making authority continues to be concentrated within institutional and political structures, while participatory mechanisms often function more as consultative spaces than as mechanisms of shared governance. Participation therefore exists within a hybrid governance environment where inclusion is expanding, but power redistribution remains limited.

At the same time, the results reveal that participatory governance in Syria continues to operate within a fragile and inconsistent legal environment. Several participants emphasized that many state institutions and local authorities still rely on legal frameworks inherited from the former regime due to the absence of newly established parliamentary and legislative structures capable of producing comprehensive legal reforms. Participants noted that transitional authorities frequently justified this situation as temporary, arguing that major legal restructuring must wait until representative legislative institutions are formally established.

However, participants also described how this legal ambiguity has created significant inconsistencies in governance practices across different regions and institutions. In several cases, local governors (Mohafez) and administrative authorities were perceived as exercising discretionary powers beyond or even in contradiction to temporary transitional regulations and decrees. This contributed to uncertainty regarding citizens' rights, participation, and protection within public and political life. As Haid noted "In the absence of a clear framework protecting peaceful political activity, decisions are left to local discretion – leaving civic actors exposed to arbitrariness and overreach"(Haid, 2026). This also reflects his broader argument that, in the absence of a clear legal framework protecting peaceful political activity, governance decisions become subject to local discretion, which can expose civic actors to arbitrariness and overreach. This demonstrates that the expansion of participation alone is insufficient without the parallel development of accountable legal and institutional frameworks. The findings therefore highlight that rebuilding trust in transitional Syria depends not only on increasing opportunities for participation, but also on strengthening the rule of law and ensuring that institutions operate through transparent and equally applied legal principles rather than individualized authority or discretionary governance practices.

Moreover, participants repeatedly linked the question of participation to broader processes of social reconstruction and trust-building. Decades of authoritarian governance, repression, and conflict were described as having fragmented Syrian society, weakened social trust, and damaged relationships both between citizens and institutions and among citizens themselves. In this sense, rebuilding Syria was understood not only as a political or economic process, but also as a social and communicative one centered on restoring trust, accountability, and shared belonging. From a CFSC perspective, this highlights that sustainable participation requires more

than formal institutional reform. It also requires rebuilding the social foundations necessary for dialogue, cooperation, and collective civic engagement. Several participants therefore framed the current transitional moment as a historically significant opportunity to gradually construct a more inclusive and participatory Syria grounded in citizenship, accountability, public trust, and the principle that the law should apply equally to all actors and institutions.

6.3 Participatory Communication and the Expansion of Civic Voice

The findings strongly support the participatory communication perspective discussed in Chapter 3 by demonstrating that communication itself has become a central arena through which participation, legitimacy, and public engagement are negotiated in transitional Syria. Tufte and Mefalopulos argue that participation should be understood as institutional inclusion, and as a communicative process shaped through dialogue, interaction, and collective meaning-making. This perspective is highly relevant in the Syrian case, where formal governance structures remain inconsistently developed, while informal communication networks increasingly shape public engagement.

Participants consistently described how social media platforms, messaging applications, community networks, and informal communication channels now function as essential spaces for expressing opinions, sharing grievances, mobilizing collective action, and negotiating public narratives. In many cases, citizens rely more heavily on digital communication platforms than on formal institutional mechanisms to engage with governance processes or make their voices heard. One example of such engagement spaces is *Salon Al-Jumhuriya*, a public dialogue initiative that enables citizens to participate in discussions with institutional actors. Through an open application process, participants can attend sessions and raise critical questions directly to government officials, creating a structured channel for public dialogue and accountability. This shift reflects what may be understood as the growing centrality of communicative participation. Participation increasingly occurs through communication practices themselves, including online discussions, digital mobilization, local media engagement, and informal community dialogue. The results therefore support Servaes'(2021) argument that dialogue represents a central component of meaningful participation and social change.

The analysis additionally suggests that digital communication spaces have partially transformed the relationship between citizens and authority. Rather than functioning solely as alternative communication tools, digital platforms increasingly operate as spaces where governance itself is publicly negotiated. Public criticism, civic mobilization, and local accountability campaigns often emerge first online before influencing institutional responses on the ground.

6.4 From Authoritarian Silence to Negotiated Participation

One of the most significant findings of this study is that the Syrian transition involves not only institutional change, but also the gradual transformation of social and communicative relations shaped by decades of authoritarian governance. In this regard, previous studies and human rights reports documented how fear, surveillance, censorship, and repression systematically restricted public participation and freedom of expression in Syria for decades Contemporary assessments, including the World Press Freedom Index by Reporters Without Borders, indicate significant changes in Syria's media landscape in the context of the political transition. Following the fall of Bashar al-Assad's regime in December 2024, Syria moved from 177th to 141st place in the Index, reflecting a shift after years of being ranked among the lowest countries globally. The results of this study suggest that many citizens now experience a greater ability to express opinions publicly, participate in demonstrations, and criticize governance actors with lower levels of fear than under previous authoritarian conditions. This represents an important transformation in the communicative and political environment across much of Syria.

Nevertheless, the legacy of authoritarianism remains deeply embedded within social relations and everyday communicative practices. Participants repeatedly described how fear, mistrust, and caution continue to shape participation even where formal restrictions have weakened. This highlights that social transformation depends on institutional reform and the creation of dialogical spaces where citizens can collectively negotiate meanings, identities, and social relations. As Tufte argues "Culture-oriented collective action emphasizing the construction of new values and identities" (2017,p. 85 -86)The Syrian case demonstrates that rebuilding participation therefore requires more than

institutional restructuring alone; it also requires rebuilding trust, communicative openness, and confidence in public engagement after decades of repression and conflict.

The results further demonstrate that Syria's transition cannot be understood solely through institutional or political developments, but must also be viewed within the broader realities of post-conflict recovery and social reconstruction. Participants emphasized that expectations of rapid democratic transformation remain unrealistic given the scale of destruction inherited from decades of authoritarian rule, prolonged conflict, economic collapse, and institutional fragmentation. The continued discovery of mass graves and ongoing public demands for justice and accountability illustrate that the transitional process remains deeply connected to unresolved questions of violence, memory, and reconciliation. At the same time, participants described noticeable improvements in certain aspects of daily life during the first phase of transition, including partial improvements in public services, electricity provision, salaries, and economic activity despite continuing economic hardship. Several participants also referred to the return of displaced Syrians and refugees as an indication of shifting perceptions of security and possibility. However, economic recovery continues to face significant obstacles due to ongoing sanctions, bureaucratic restrictions, weak institutions, and the long-term consequences of war and economic devastation.

Chapter 7. Conclusion

This chapter concludes the study by summarizing the main findings in relation to the research questions and theoretical framework. It also reflects on the broader implications of the study for participation, governance, and ComDev in transitional Syria, while offering recommendations for practice and directions for future research.

This study set out to explore how patterns of public participation in Syria have changed following the fall of the Assad regime, with particular attention to the interaction between citizens, local governance actors, and communication processes across different governance contexts. Drawing on qualitative interviews, discourse analysis, and document analysis, the findings demonstrate that participation in transitional Syria is shaped by a complex and unequally structured governance landscape characterized by hybridity, fragmentation, and the ongoing negotiation of authority.

The study shows that participation in Syria cannot be understood through formal institutional frameworks alone. Instead, participation emerges through a combination of formal and informal practices mediated by local actors, civil society organizations, humanitarian structures, community leaders, and digital communication networks. Across Damascus and Rural Damascus, Northwest Syria, and Northeast Syria, participation takes different forms depending on local political conditions, institutional arrangements, and levels of control. While some spaces for civic engagement and public dialogue have expanded following the fall of the regime, access to meaningful influence over decision-making remains highly uneven.

The results further demonstrate that participation in Syria is largely consultative and mediated rather than fully transformative. In many cases, citizens are able to express concerns, share opinions, or engage in local initiatives, yet their ability to directly shape policies and governance outcomes remains limited. Arnstein's framework proved particularly useful in illustrating how many participatory mechanisms continue to operate within the levels of informing, consultation, and limited placation rather than genuine citizen power. At the same time, the analysis also reveals the emergence of localized and bottom-up forms of engagement that challenge purely top-down understandings of governance.

An important contribution of this study is the identification of participation as a communicative and negotiated process. Communication practices - including social media platforms, informal networks, local dialogue forums, and intermediary actors - play a central role in shaping how participation is experienced and enacted. In contexts where institutional trust remains fragile and formal participatory structures are weak or inconsistent, citizens often rely on informal and digital communication spaces to express concerns, mobilize collectively, and engage with governance processes. These communicative spaces therefore function not only as channels of information exchange, but also as spaces where legitimacy, inclusion, and public voice are continuously negotiated.

At the same time, the study highlights the enduring influence of Syria's authoritarian legacy on participation. Fear, mistrust, self-censorship, and uncertainty continue to shape citizens' willingness to engage publicly, even in contexts where civic space has partially expanded. Participation is therefore constrained not only by institutional

limitations, but also by internalized social and political dynamics rooted in decades of authoritarian governance and conflict. This demonstrates that the transition in Syria involves not only institutional transformation, but also the gradual renegotiation of social relations, public trust, and political culture.

Overall, the study argues that Syria's current transitional phase reflects a shift from centralized authoritarian control toward a more negotiated and hybrid form of participation. However, this transition remains incomplete, unstable, and unequally developed across regions and governance environments. Participation in Syria today exists within a fluid landscape where formal institutions, informal practices, civil society actors, and communication networks interact in shaping public life. Rather than representing a linear movement toward democratic governance, participation in transitional Syria should therefore be understood as an ongoing process of negotiation over power, legitimacy, inclusion, and voice. Furthermore, the Syrian transition presents characteristics that distinguish it from many conventional post-conflict and democratization cases. The country is simultaneously dealing with the legacies of more than five decades of authoritarian rule, the consequences of prolonged armed conflict, economic collapse, large-scale displacement, and the reconstruction of state institutions. At the same time, citizens continue to demand accountability, justice, and greater inclusion in public affairs while navigating immediate social and economic challenges. These overlapping processes suggest that participation cannot be evaluated solely through institutional indicators, but must also be understood in relation to broader societal efforts to rebuild trust, public life, and state–society relations. Consequently, Syria highlights the importance of developing context-sensitive approaches within ComDev that recognize participation as an evolving and multidimensional process rather than a fixed institutional outcome.

7.1 Recommendations for Practice

Based on the findings of this study, several recommendations can be proposed for governance actors, civil society organizations, and ComDev practitioners working within Syria's transitional context.

7.1.1 For Local Governance Institutions and Authorities

Local governance actors should move beyond symbolic consultation mechanisms and work toward more transparent and inclusive forms of participation. This includes creating clearer and formal channels through which citizens can influence local decision-making processes and receive feedback regarding how their concerns are addressed. Participation should not be limited to one-way communication or public information campaigns, but should involve ongoing dialogue and accountability mechanisms that strengthen trust between institutions and communities.

In addition, local governance structures should recognize the growing importance of digital communication spaces in shaping civic engagement. Social media platforms and online communication channels should be integrated into broader participatory strategies in ways that encourage meaningful interaction rather than simply institutional visibility.

7.1.2 For Civil Society Organizations and NGOs

Civil society organizations play a critical intermediary role within Syria's governance landscape and should continue supporting locally grounded and community-driven participation initiatives. At the same time, organizations should be cautious of reproducing forms of professionalized participation that primarily engage a narrow group of activists, experts, or local elites while excluding broader segments of society.

Greater attention should therefore be given to including marginalized voices, strengthening local ownership, and supporting long-term community trust-building processes. In addition, NGOs should expand capacity-building workshops and awareness initiatives that promote civic engagement, dialogue, participation, and the rebuilding of civil society within transitional communities.

7.1.3 For ComDev Practitioners

The findings emphasize the importance of communication as a central component of participation and governance in transitional Syria. ComDev practitioners should therefore focus on strengthening dialogical and community-based communication approaches that encourage local engagement, collective reflection, and bottom-up participation.

Communication strategies should recognize the interconnected nature of digital and physical participation spaces. Informal communication networks, local media initiatives, community forums, and digital platforms all play important roles in shaping public engagement and should be approached as complementary rather than separate spaces.

Furthermore, participatory communication initiatives should prioritize trust-building, inclusivity, and locally relevant communication practices rather than relying solely on institutional or externally driven messaging approaches.

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Appendices

Appendix A: Statement of Individual Contributions

This thesis was conducted as a collaborative project by Maryam Alhalak and Taleb Nasab. All major decisions regarding the research topic, research design, data analysis, interpretation of findings, and final editing were discussed and undertaken jointly. As a married couple working closely together throughout the entire research process, we collaborated continuously on all aspects of the study and jointly reviewed and revised every chapter.

To clarify our individual contributions for assessment purposes:

Maryam Alhalak had primary responsibility for the literature review and theoretical framework chapters. She also conducted 8 of the 15 semi-structured interviews and contributed to data analysis, interpretation, writing, and editing throughout the thesis.

Taleb Nasab had primary responsibility for the overall structure, organization, and visual design of the thesis. He conducted 7 of the 15 semi-structured interviews and contributed to data analysis, interpretation, writing, and editing throughout the thesis.

Although certain tasks were divided according to our strengths and areas of responsibility, the thesis should be understood as a genuinely collaborative effort. All chapters were discussed, reviewed, and revised jointly, and both authors contributed to the development of the research questions, methodology, analysis, conclusions, and final manuscript.

Appendix B: Digital Tools and AI-Assisted Research Workflow

This study acknowledges the use of digital tools, including artificial intelligence (AI), as supportive instruments throughout the research and writing process. AI-based platforms, including ChatGPT, Microsoft Copilot, and Google Gemini, were mainly used for language refinement, structural coherence, and identifying relevant academic concepts and literature directions. Some figures and visual materials were also generated with the assistance of AI tools. All AI-generated outputs were critically reviewed, compared, and adapted according to academic relevance and context.

For data collection and transcription, Microsoft Teams was used to conduct, record, and transcribe interviews. In some cases, interviews conducted through platforms such as WhatsApp were also transcribed using Microsoft Teams to maintain consistency in data management.

Appendix C: Interview Guide

Project Title: Shifts in Public Participation in Syria (FC2G); **Interview Metadata**

- **Interview No:** _____
- **Date:** _____
- **Method:** ☐ Teams ☐ WhatsApp call
- **Region:** ☐ Damascus & Rural Damascus ☐ North-West ☐ North-East

- **Gender:** ☐ Female ☐ Male

Introduction (Approx. 15 mins)

Objective of the Study: "Hello, thank you very much for your time. My name is Maryam/Taleb, and I am conducting research for my Master's thesis. Our study focuses on understanding community participation in Syria, specifically how people participate - or do not participate - in decision-making processes that affect their lives. We are interested in your personal experience and whether you feel your voice is heard. There are no right or wrong answers."

Informed Consent and Data Usage:

- **Recording:** Seek permission to record for research purposes.
- **Anonymity:** Clarify if the participant agrees to use their real name and role or prefers a pseudonym.
- **Consent:** Confirm verbal consent after starting the recording.

Main Interview Questions (40–45 mins)

1. Information and Access
- **Q1.** How do people in your surroundings usually get information about government initiatives or local projects (humanitarian, service, or organizational)?
- **Q2.** Based on your role, can you describe a situation where you were informed about a specific decision?

2. Consultation and Participation
- **Q3.** Have you ever been asked to share your opinion on a local issue? Can you describe that experience?
- **Q4.** What happened after you shared your opinion? Did you feel the participation was symbolic or genuine and influential?

3. Influence and Decision-Making
- **Q5.** To what extent do you feel people like you can influence decisions in your area (governmental or local)?
- **Q6.** Who usually makes the final decisions in your community? (Authorities, NGOs, Local Leaders, Jointly, etc.)

4. Challenges and Power Dynamics
- **Q7.** What are the main challenges people face when trying to participate in decisions? (Fear, lack of trust, access, etc.)
- **Q8.** Do you think participation depends on personal connections (Wasata), background, or social status? How?

5. Adaptation and Informal Practices
- **Q9.** How do people deal with limited or difficult participation? Do they use informal methods?
- **Q10.** If people feel their voices are not heard, can they express their opinions publicly (e.g., protests)? How is this handled?

6. Change Over Time (Key Question)
- **Q11.** Have you noticed any changes in participation patterns over the past year? Please describe them.

7. Media and Communication
- **Q12.** How do people use social media or digital platforms to express opinions or participate?
- **Q13.** What is your opinion on official media and communication with the government? Does the media reflect the voice of the people or the voice of authority? t

Closing & Researcher Notes

- **Key Takeaways:** _____

- **Significant Quotes:** _____
- **Follow-up required:** _____

Appendix D: Ethical Considerations

- Informed consent obtained from all participants prior to interviews
- Participation was voluntary with the right to withdraw at any time
- Audio /video recordings will be deleted after this study
- Special care was taken due to political sensitivity of the context
- Study follows Malmö University ethical research guidelines

Appendix E: Data Overview

- Number of interviews conducted: **15**
- Participant categories:
    - Local governance actors
    - NGO / humanitarian workers
    - Civil society actors
- Data collection method: Semi-structured interviews (online)
- Languages used: Arabic
- Transcription method: Teams auto transcription

I. Participants Overview

No.	Name	Gender	Geographical Region	Job Title / Role
1	Samia	Female	Damascus	PE Teacher, HR manager (Hathihi Hayati Org), Volunteer Manager
2	Farah	Female	Rural Damascus	Medical Student, NGO Volunteer, Social media influencer
3	Tariq	Male	NW (Idlib) - Damascus	Grant Manager at Syrian for Development
4	Eng. Rafee	Male	Rural Damascus	Electrical Engineer (Energy Efficiency & Measurement Specialist) / Civil Society Activist
5	Aya	Female	Rural Damascus	Administrative and Financial Staff at a Medical Point (SARC)
6	Nour	Female	NE (Deir Ez-Zor)	Academic researcher. Education officer NGO
7	Hani	Male	NE (Al-Hasakah)	Entrepreneur and Civil Society Activist
8	Nozad	Male	NE (Al-Hasakah)	Researcher and Capacity Building Expert, working with International and Local NGOs
9	Rahaf	Female	NE (Al-Hasakah)	Government/ Service Sector Employee (Youth Empowerment Directorate)
10	Basheer	Male	NW (Aleppo) - Damascus	Government/ Grants Manager at the Syrian Development Fund (SYDF)
11	Yasin	Male	NW (Idlib)	Contractor in the Reconstruction Sector
12	Dr. Saad	Male	NE (Qamishly)	Academic researcher, and Political/Administrative Expert
13	Hamren	Female	NE (Al-Hasakah)	Head of Al-Darbasiyah Municipality
14	Mahmoud	Male	NW (Aleppo)	Humanitarian and Development Worker (Development Org, formerly SAMS)
15	Dr. Samar	Female	NE (Al-Hasakah)	Former Pharmacist, Current Director of Syrian Medical Association.